

How to Lose Friends and Alienate Co-Workers

We can write code in many ways that result in identical behavior. For example, we can write a list with a single space after each comma and use one kind of quote character consistently:

```
spam = ['dog', 'cat', 'moose']
```

But even if we wrote the list with a varying number of spaces and quote styles, we'd still have syntactically valid Python code:

```
spam= [ 'dog'  , 'cat', "moose"]
```

Programmers who prefer the former approach might like the visual separation that the spaces add and the uniformity of the quote characters. But programmers sometimes choose the latter, because they don't want to worry about details that have no impact on whether the program works correctly.

Beginners often ignore code formatting because they're focused on programming concepts and language syntax. But it's valuable for beginners to establish good code formatting habits. Programming is difficult enough, and writing understandable code for others (or for yourself in the future) can minimize this problem.

Although you might start out coding on your own, programming is often a collaborative activity. If several programmers working on the same source code files write in their own style, the code can become an inconsistent mess, even if it runs without error. Or worse, the programmers will constantly be reformatting each other's code to their own style, wasting time and causing arguments. Deciding whether to, say, put one or zero spaces after a comma is a matter of personal preference. These style choices can be much like deciding which side of the road to drive on; it doesn't matter whether people drive on the right side of the road or the left side, as long as everyone consistently drives on the same side.